OMMUNICATION SKILLS | LLC1011 · B.TECH 1ST YEAR · MUJ | EXAM-READY NOTES

Communication Skills

LLC1011 — Complete Exam Notes with PYQs & Answer Strategy

How to think, structure & write perfect answers — not just rote theory.

Communication & Barriers | Listening Skills | Presentation & Speaking | Email & Letter Writing | Resume Writing | Reading & Comprehension | Soft Skills & GD

Compiled by Akshit Raj · mujstella.in

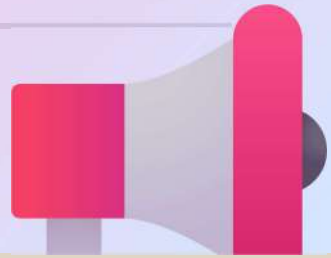


TABLE OF CONTENTS

U1 Communication: Fundamentals, Types & Barriers

U2 Listening, Speaking & Presentation Skills

U3 Writing Skills: Email, Letters & Paragraphs

U4 Resume, Reading, Soft Skills & GD

UNIT 1

Communication: Fundamentals, Types & Barriers

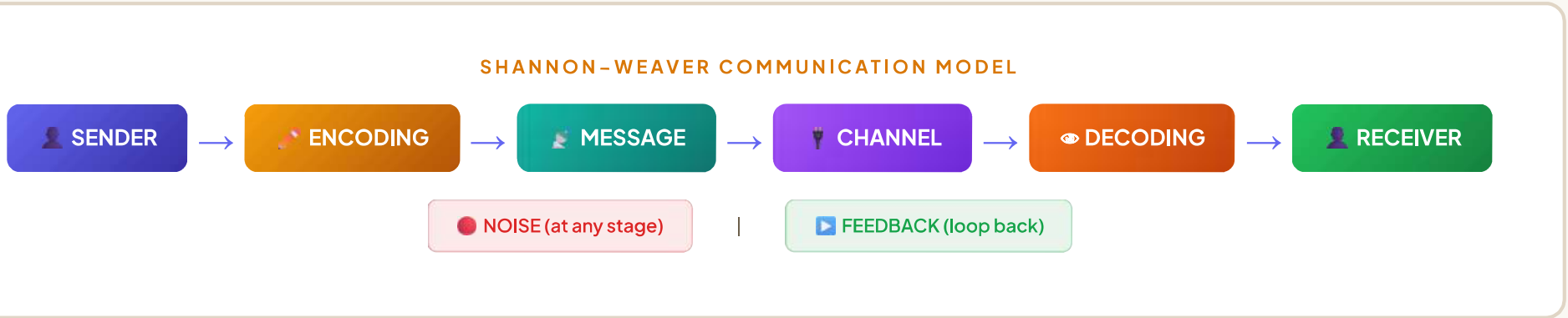
💡 **What this unit is really about:** Understand communication as a *process with identifiable parts*, classify its types, and recognize what breaks it. Questions ask you to *define, classify, or analyze* — always use structured bullet answers with bold headings.

DEFINITION & CORE CONCEPT

The word **communication** comes from the Latin *communicare* — "to share." It is the process of transferring information, ideas, feelings, or messages between a **sender** and a **receiver** through a **medium**, resulting in a shared understanding.

✍️ **Exam-ready one-liner:** "Communication is the dynamic, two-way process of transmitting meaning between individuals through verbal or non-verbal channels, with feedback confirming understanding."

THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS



COMPONENT	WHAT IT IS	EXAMPLE
Sender	Initiates the message; the encoder	A manager giving instructions
Encoding	Converting thoughts into symbols/words	Choosing words, tone, gestures
Message	The actual content being communicated	The instruction itself
Channel	Medium of transmission	Email, phone, face-to-face
Decoding	Receiver interprets the message	Understanding the instruction
Receiver	Destination of the message	The team member
Feedback	Receiver's response confirming receipt	Reply email / nod / action
Noise	Any distortion disrupting the process	Poor internet, language barrier

FEATURES / CHARACTERISTICS OF COMMUNICATION

CORE FEATURES

- **Two-way process** — sender and receiver both participate
- **Dynamic** — constantly changing based on context
- **Unavoidable** — even silence communicates something
- **Purposeful** — aims for a specific response or action

MORE FEATURES

- **Verbal & Non-verbal** — words + gestures/expressions
- **Feedback-driven** — incomplete without response
- **Contextual** — influenced by culture, time, place
- **Enables understanding** — shared meaning is the goal

GOALS / SIGNIFICANCE OF COMMUNICATION

- **To Inform** — share data, news, updates
- **To Persuade** — change attitudes, opinions, behaviour
- **To Motivate** — inspire action or effort

- **To Build Relationships** — foster trust and rapport
- **To Express** — convey feelings and emotions
- **To Coordinate** — align team activities toward a goal

TYPES OF COMMUNICATION

> 💡 **Trick to remember types:** Think of 3 dimensions — **Mode** (verbal/non-verbal), **Number of people** (intra/inter/org/mass), **Direction of flow** (downward/upward/horizontal/diagonal).

By Mode

💬 VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Uses **words** — spoken or written.

- **Oral:** face-to-face, phone, presentations, GDs
- **Written:** emails, letters, reports, resumes

> ✨ Verbal = precise, recordable, but can be misinterpreted without tone.

🎈 NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Conveys meaning **without words**. Studies show: `7% words | 38% tone | 55% body language`

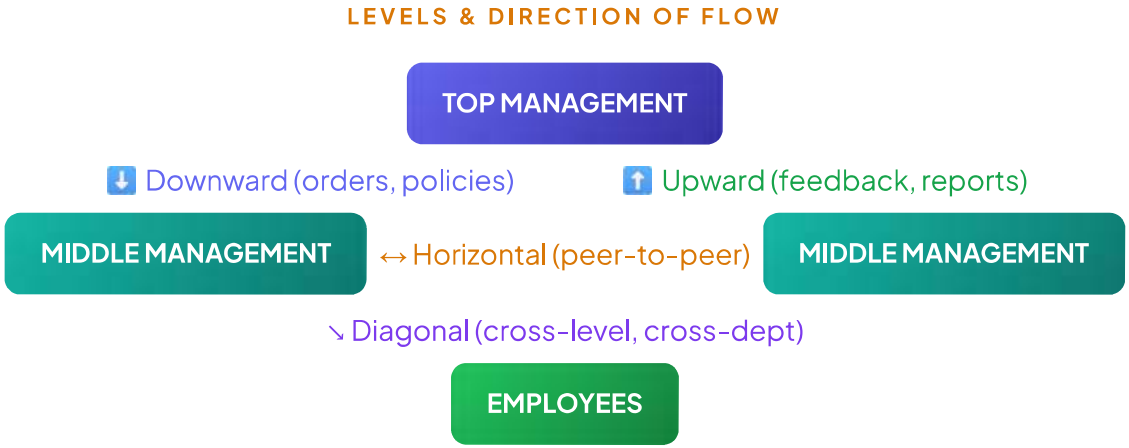
- **Kinesics** — body movements, gestures, posture
- **Oculesics** — eye contact
- **Proxemics** — personal space & distance
- **Haptics** — touch (handshake etc.)
- **Chronemics** — use of time (punctuality)
- **Paralingual** — tone, pitch, pace, volume

By Number of Participants

TYPE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE
Intrapersonal	Communication with oneself — inner dialogue	Self-reflection, planning
Interpersonal	Between two or more individuals; face-to-face or mediated	Conversation, interview
Organizational	Within organizations — formal structures	Office memos, meetings

TYPE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE
Mass Communication	Reaching large audiences via media	TV news, social media

Organizational Communication Flow



Intercultural Communication

Communication between people from **different cultural backgrounds**. Key challenges: different norms for eye contact, formality, silence, punctuality, and directness. Essential in global/multinational teams.

🌐 **Exam tip:** If asked about global teams or multinational scenarios, always mention intercultural communication as a factor causing misunderstandings.

BARRIERS TO COMMUNICATION

⚠️ **Barrier = anything that distorts or blocks the message.** Technically called "noise" — not just sound, but any interference in the communication process.

Physical Barriers

Environmental noise, distance, technical issues, poor infrastructure

Psychological Barriers

Emotions, prejudice, lack of interest, distraction, fear

Semantic Barriers

Ambiguous words, jargon, language difference, poor vocabulary

Organizational Barriers

Too many hierarchy levels, information overload, fear of superiors

Interpersonal Barriers

Poor listening, cultural differences, emotional outbursts, selectivity

Intrapersonal Barriers

Wrong assumptions, varied perceptions, categorical thinking, biases

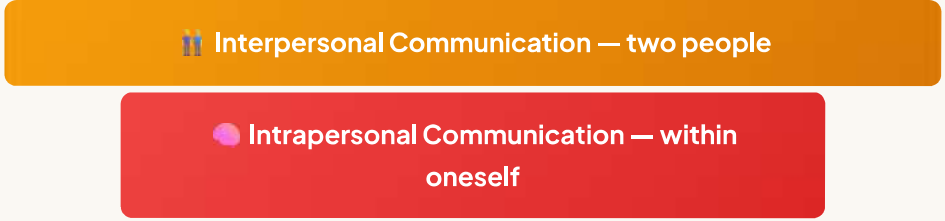
BARRIER TYPE	CAUSES	HOW TO OVERCOME
Physical	Loud environment, bad tech, distance	Better infrastructure, quiet space, better tools
Psychological	Stress, bias, emotional state	Active listening, emotional intelligence
Semantic	Jargon, ambiguous words, language gap	Simple language, confirm understanding, use examples
Organizational	Multiple relay stations, fear culture	Flat structure, open-door policy, feedback culture
Cultural	Different norms, assumptions	Cultural sensitivity training, awareness

LEVELS OF COMMUNICATION

🌎 Mass Communication — millions of people, one-to-many

🏢 Organizational Communication — within institutions

🤝 Group Communication — teams, meetings, GDs



Pyramid shows: wider base = more people involved; apex = most personal

📋 PAST YEAR QUESTIONS — UNIT 1

ETE 2025 2 Marks · Section A (20–30 words)

Q. Name any four barriers to effective communication.

Four barriers to effective communication are:

1. **Physical Barriers** — noise, distance, poor connectivity
2. **Psychological Barriers** — stress, bias, emotional disturbance
3. **Semantic Barriers** — jargon, ambiguous language, vocabulary mismatch
4. **Organizational Barriers** — information overload, fear of superiors, excessive relay stations

✅ **How to write this:** Section A is 20–30 words. Just number them clearly. No explanation needed — the question says "name," not "explain." Four neat lines = full marks.

ETE 2025 2 Marks · Section A

Q. What are the primary goals of communication?

The primary goals of communication are: to **inform** (share knowledge), to **persuade** (influence decisions), to **motivate** (inspire action), and to **build relationships** (create trust and understanding).

✅ **How to write this:** Use the format: "to [verb] — [brief explanation]" for each goal. 4 goals in one smooth sentence or 4 short bullets = 20–30 words exactly.

MAKEUP 2025-26 2 Marks · Section A

Q. Provide a micro-scenario showing how downward communication can unintentionally create fear-based compliance.

A manager emails the team: *"All pending work must be submitted by 5 PM — no exceptions."* Employees, fearing repercussions, submit incomplete reports rather than seeking clarification. The authoritative tone triggers compliance through fear, not genuine commitment, suppressing honest upward feedback.

✅ **How to write this:** Scenario questions need a *concrete mini-story* (2–3 sentences) with a clear cause-effect. Show the "downward" direction explicitly (manager → employee), and name the outcome (fear, not genuine compliance).

MAKEUP 2025-26 6 Marks · Section B (150–200 words)

Q. Analyse how poor channel selection (e.g., sending sensitive updates via group chat) can damage workplace trust. Provide real or realistic corporate scenarios.

Introduction: Channel selection is critical — the *medium shapes the message*. Choosing the wrong channel for sensitive information destroys psychological safety and erodes trust.

Scenario 1 — Performance Warning via Group Chat: A manager sends a performance warning to an employee in a shared WhatsApp group. The employee feels humiliated publicly; colleagues feel uncomfortable. Trust in management collapses.

Scenario 2 — Layoff News via Mass Email: A company announces retrenchment by mass email without prior one-on-one conversations. Employees feel dehumanized; morale plummets, and remaining staff lose loyalty.

Analysis: Sensitive communication demands channels that ensure **privacy**, **empathy**, and **two-way dialogue** — such as face-to-face meetings or private calls. Group chats lack these; the sender's convenience overrides the receiver's dignity.

Conclusion: Effective communicators match channel to context. When privacy and sensitivity are required, asynchronous or public channels are always the wrong choice.

✅ **Structure for 6-mark B-section:** Intro (1 line) + 2 Scenarios with analysis + Conclusion. Always use **bold headings** per paragraph. ~150–200 words is strict — be concise.

MAKEUP 2025-26 20 Marks · Section D (450–500 words)

Q. A rapidly expanding tech startup employs teams from five countries… Use this situation to examine the deeper causes of poor communication and create a practical model for diagnosing and improving it.

Introduction: The scenario reveals a systemic communication breakdown rooted in multicultural friction, channel mismatch, and inadequate professional skills training.

Root Cause 1 — Noise & Channel Mismatch: Informal chat messages lack tone, punctuality cues, and context. When teams from high-context cultures (Japan, India) receive blunt low-context messages (USA, Germany), misinterpretation is inevitable. *Solution:* Establish a Channel Policy — video calls for ambiguous topics, email for formal records, chat only for quick confirmations.

Root Cause 2 — Poor Listening & Reading Skills: Employees skim technical reports without intensive reading strategies, leading to operational errors. *Solution:* Train in SQ3R (Survey, Question, Read, Recite, Review) for report reading; run active listening workshops.

Root Cause 3 — Presentation Failures: Client demos fail when presenters read slides verbatim rather than engaging. *Solution:* Apply the 10–20–30 rule (10 slides, 20 min, 30pt font); practice delivery, not just slide design.

Root Cause 4 — GD Dominance & Cultural Barriers: Employees from low power-distance cultures dominate; those from hierarchical backgrounds stay silent. *Solution:* Facilitate structured GDs with timed rounds, rotating moderators, and explicit turn-taking norms.

Root Cause 5 — Negotiation & Persuasion Gaps: Without soft skills in persuasion (ethos, pathos, logos) and diversity awareness, negotiations stall. *Solution:* Cross-cultural training + negotiation workshops using BATNA (Best Alternative to a Negotiated Agreement) frameworks.

Diagnostic Model — CLEAR:

- **C**hannel — Is the right medium being used?
- **L**istening — Is active, empathetic listening practiced?
- **E**ncoding — Is the message clear and culturally appropriate?
- **A**wareness — Do participants have diversity & soft-skills awareness?
- **R**eading — Are written materials read with comprehension strategies?

Conclusion: Poor communication in global teams is never just a language problem — it is a systems problem. The CLEAR model provides a diagnostic checklist that the startup's HR can deploy at onboarding and quarterly reviews to build a communication-competent, inclusive workforce.

✅ **How to write 20-mark answers:** These need 450–500 words — that is roughly one A4 page. Use 5–6 numbered/headed paragraphs. Always end with a model, framework, or named conclusion. Examiners reward *structure* over quantity of content. Use bold headings for every point.

⚠ **Common mistake:** Writing a wall of text. Always break into labelled sections. A messy 500-word essay scores less than a clean 400-word structured answer.

UNIT 2

Listening, Speaking & Presentation Skills

💡 **What this unit is really about:** The *active skills* of communication — not passive reception. Examiners love questions on types of listening, how to do a good presentation, and public speaking. Answers should be practical and structured, not vague.

LISTENING SKILLS

Hearing vs. Listening

HEARING (PASSIVE)

- Physiological, involuntary process
- Sound waves hit the eardrum — automatic
- No effort or attention required
- No comprehension guaranteed

LISTENING (ACTIVE)

- Conscious, deliberate cognitive process
- Involves attention, interpretation & response
- Requires focus, retention & empathy
- Results in understanding and feedback

✍️ **One-liner for exams:** "Hearing is biological; listening is psychological. Hearing perceives sound; listening creates meaning."

Types of Listening

TYPE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHEN USED
Active Listening	Full attention + conscious engagement + feedback. The highest form.	Counselling, interviews, conflict resolution
Passive Listening	Listening without responding or engaging. Low involvement.	Lectures, radio, background TV
Empathetic Listening	Highest level — understanding the speaker's emotions, not just words	Personal counselling, HR interactions
Critical Listening	Analysing and evaluating the message for logic and accuracy	Debates, sales pitches, news

TYPE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHEN USED
Appreciative Listening	Listening for enjoyment or aesthetic pleasure	Music, poetry, storytelling
Informative Listening	Listening to gather facts and information	Classroom, training sessions
Precision Listening	Listening for specific details about speaker's emotional state	Negotiations, sensitive discussions

Barriers to Effective Listening

INTERNAL BARRIERS

- Preconceived notions / prejudice
- Emotional disturbance
- Mental wandering / daydreaming
- Impatience with the speaker

EXTERNAL BARRIERS

- Physical noise in environment
- Poor acoustics
- Distractions (phone, movement)
- Uncomfortable setting

LINGUISTIC BARRIERS

- Unfamiliar vocabulary / accent
- Too-fast speech
- Jargon or technical language
- Paraphrasing distortion

PUBLIC SPEAKING & DEBATES

Public Speaking

The art of communicating effectively with a **large audience**. Involves preparation, delivery, body language, and audience management.

The 3 P's of Public Speaking:

Prepare → Practice → Present

- **Know your audience** — adapt vocabulary, tone and examples to them
- **Structure your speech** — Introduction (hook), Body (3 key points), Conclusion (call to action)
- **Manage nerves** — breathe, make eye contact, pause deliberately
- **Use vocal variety** — vary pitch, pace, volume for emphasis
- **Non-verbal confidence** — stand straight, open gestures, smile

Debates

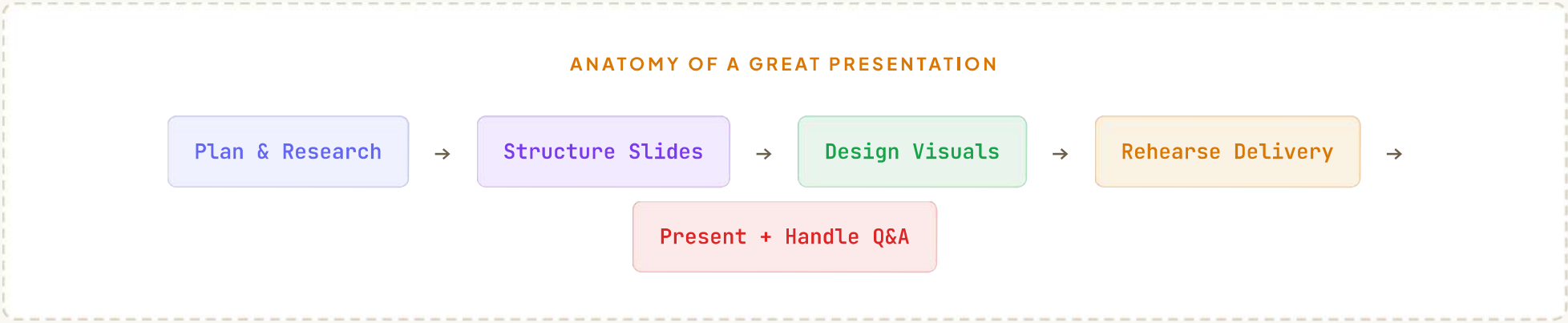
Formal argument where participants take opposing positions and defend them with evidence and reasoning. Key elements: **proposition, opposition, evidence, rebuttal**, and adherence to **time limits**.

> 🎯 **Debate vs. GD:** A debate has fixed sides (for/against); a GD is open discussion toward consensus. In exams, don't confuse them.

PRESENTATION SKILLS

Dynamics of a Professional Presentation

> 🌟 **The Golden Rule:** The presentation is there to *support you* — not to replace you. Slides are visual aids, not a script. You are the presenter; the PPT is the prop.



🌟 Tips for an Effective PowerPoint (PPT)

✅ DO

- **6×6 Rule:** Max 6 bullets per slide, max 6 words per bullet
- Use readable fonts: Arial, Tahoma, Calibri (min 24pt for body)
- One idea per slide — don't cram
- Use high-quality, relevant images

❌ DON'T

- Don't use ALL CAPS (hard to read, feels aggressive)
- Don't use too many animations/transitions — it distracts
- Don't use clashing colours (green on blue, red on green)
- Don't use fonts below 18pt for any content

- Maintain consistent background and colour scheme
- Use contrasting colours (dark text on light BG or vice versa)
- Practice the delivery — not just slide creation
- Add slide numbers and a clear title slide

- Don't read slides word-for-word to the audience
- Don't use low-resolution or irrelevant images
- Don't change background styles mid-presentation
- Don't exceed your allotted time

10-20-30 Rule: 10 slides maximum | 20 minutes maximum | 30pt minimum font size

Verbal vs. Audio-Visual Communication in Presentations

ASPECT	VERBAL COMPONENT	AUDIO-VISUAL COMPONENT
Definition	Spoken words, tone, pace, emphasis	Slides, charts, images, videos
Purpose	Explain, persuade, engage	Reinforce, illustrate, clarify
Advantage	Flexible, spontaneous, personal	Memorable, visual impact, data display
Risk	Forgettable without visual support	Can distract from speaker

GROUP DISCUSSION (GD)

A GD is a structured discussion among 6–12 participants on a given topic, aimed at exploring ideas and reaching conclusions. Evaluated in placements and interviews.

WHAT EVALUATORS LOOK FOR

- Content quality — are your points relevant?
- Communication clarity — are you understood?
- Leadership — do you initiate or summarize?
- Listening — do you build on others' points?
- Confidence without aggression
- Body language and eye contact

GD STRATEGY

- **Initiate** if you have a strong opening — it's noted
- **Use data/examples** — "According to a 2023 report..."
- **Acknowledge others** — "Building on what X said..."
- **Avoid interrupting** — wait for a natural pause
- **Summarize** at the end — summarizers are valued
- **Stay calm** if things get heated — maturity is noticed

PERSONAL INTERVIEW SKILLS

- **Research the company** before the interview — know their products, values, recent news
- **Use the STAR method** for behavioural questions: *Situation → Task → Action → Result*
- **Dress professionally** — first impressions are non-verbal communication
- **Listen carefully** before answering — don't interrupt the interviewer
- **Prepare questions to ask** — shows interest and initiative
- **Manage silences** — a thoughtful pause is better than a rushed wrong answer

SOFT SKILLS: CRITICAL THINKING, PERSUASION & DIVERSITY AWARENESS

Critical Thinking

The ability to **analyse, evaluate, and form reasoned judgements** rather than accepting information at face value. Key in debates, GDs, and professional decision-making.

Persuasion & Negotiation

Persuasion uses **ethos** (credibility), **pathos** (emotion), and **logos** (logic) to influence. Negotiation seeks a mutually beneficial outcome — *win-win*, not win-lose.

Diversity Awareness

Recognizing and respecting differences in **culture, language, gender, religion, and background** in communication. Essential for inclusive workplaces and global teams.

Technology in Communication

Digital tools (email, video calls, messaging apps, social media) have increased speed but reduced nuance. Key risks: misinterpretation of text, information overload, digital divide, privacy issues. Balance technology with human-centred communication.

📋 PAST YEAR QUESTIONS — UNIT 2

ETE 2025 2 Marks · Section A

Q. Explain the significance of passive listening.

Passive listening occurs when one receives sounds *without active engagement or response*. Its significance: it allows absorption of background information (e.g., radio, lectures), provides relaxation, and can subtly inform the listener without cognitive effort. However, it risks missing critical details due to lack of focus.

✅ **How to write:** Define it in one line, then list 2–3 significances. End with a one-line limitation so your answer seems balanced and critical. ~25 words.

ETE 2025 2 Marks · Section A

Q. What is the significance of visual aids in a presentation?

Visual aids (slides, charts, images) enhance presentations by: (1) reinforcing spoken content visually, (2) aiding memory retention, (3) simplifying complex data, and (4) maintaining audience attention. They act as a bridge between the speaker's ideas and the audience's understanding.

✅ **How to write:** Number your points (1)(2)(3)(4) — it looks structured even in 25 words. End with a purpose statement.

ETE 2025 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Discuss the key elements of making and delivering an effective PowerPoint presentation.

Introduction: An effective presentation integrates thoughtful design with confident delivery — the slide deck supports the speaker, not the other way around.

1. Content Structure: Follow a clear arc — Title Slide → Agenda → Body (3–5 key points) → Summary → Q&A. Each slide should communicate ONE idea only.

2. Slide Design: Apply the 6×6 rule (max 6 bullets, 6 words each). Use readable fonts (min 24pt), consistent colour scheme, and high-resolution relevant images. Avoid clashing colours and excessive animation.

3. Delivery: Maintain eye contact — speak TO the audience, not to the screen. Use vocal variety (pace, tone, emphasis). Adhere to the 10–20–30 rule (10 slides, 20 min, 30pt font).

4. Practice: Rehearse multiple times — knowing your content reduces dependence on slides and boosts confidence.

Conclusion: A great presentation balances visual clarity, structured content, and engaging delivery to leave a lasting impression.

✅ **Structure for B-section:** 4–5 numbered/bold paragraphs. Each = 1 key element + brief explanation. Intro + Conclusion frame the answer. ~160–180 words is ideal.

MAKEUP 2025-26 2 Marks · Section A

Q. Give one example where lack of soft-skill diversity awareness harms teamwork quality.

In a multicultural project team, an Indian member's use of indirect refusal ("I will try") is misread by a German colleague as agreement, causing deadline conflicts. The resulting frustration — rooted in cultural unawareness — undermines team cohesion and project delivery.

✅ **How to write:** One specific, realistic scenario with named cultures, a clear misunderstanding, and a named consequence. Concrete > vague always.

MAKEUP 2025-26 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Compare the communication strategies needed in formal debates and persuasive presentations, using real-life examples.

Introduction: Both debates and persuasive presentations aim to influence an audience, but their strategies differ in structure, tone, and interactivity.

Formal Debate Strategy: Debates require rapid argumentation, rebuttal, and evidence marshalling under time pressure. Speakers must anticipate the opposition's points and counter them with logic (logos) and credibility (ethos). Example: In a parliamentary debate on AI regulation, participants cite statistics and refute opposing data in real-time.

Persuasive Presentation Strategy: Presentations are one-directional; the speaker controls the narrative. Emotional appeal (pathos) is more accessible here — storytelling, visuals, and a clear call-to-action are key. Example: A TED talk on climate change uses personal stories and data visualizations to persuade without opposition.

Key Difference: Debates demand adaptability and counter-argument; presentations demand preparation and narrative control. Both require clarity, confidence, and audience awareness.

> ✅ **How to write:** Always use "real-life examples" as the question demands. Name the format (debate/presentation), describe the strategy, give a concrete example. Compare explicitly in the conclusion.

UNIT 3

Writing Skills: Email, Letters & Paragraphs

> 💡 **What this unit is really about:** Professional writing that is clear, structured, and purposeful. Examiners test whether you can *produce* writing (emails, letters) and *explain* the principles. Always use format + content + tone — all three must show up.

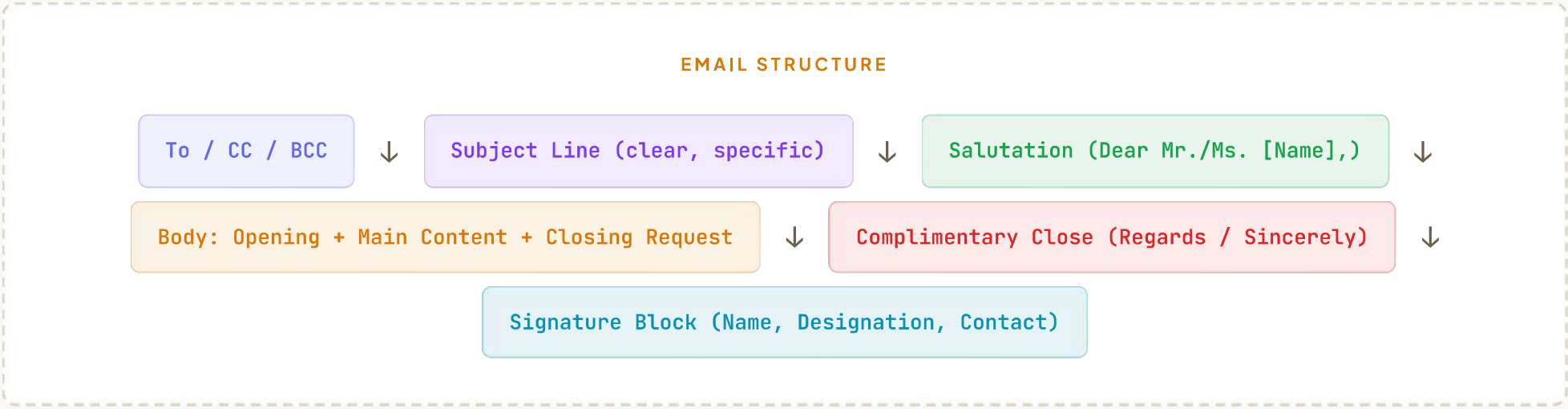
EMAIL WRITING

Why Emails Are Popular

- **Fast, cheap, and accessible** — instant global reach
- **Legally valid** — emails serve as written records

- **Flexible in tone** — can be formal or semi-formal
- **Asynchronous** — sender and receiver don't need to be available simultaneously

Structure of a Professional Email



Email Etiquette — Do's & Don'ts

✅ BEST PRACTICES

- Use a clear, descriptive subject line
- Start with a warm-up sentence ("I hope this email finds you well.")
- Be concise — one purpose per email
- Use proper spelling, grammar, punctuation
- Reply promptly (within 24 hours)
- Use active voice
- Re-read before sending
- Use BCC for mass mails (protect privacy)

❌ AVOID THESE

- Do NOT write in ALL CAPS (rude/aggressive)
- Don't use Reply All unnecessarily
- Avoid jargon, emoticons in formal email
- Don't mark non-urgent emails as URGENT/IMPORTANT
- Don't discuss confidential matters via email
- Avoid long, dense paragraphs
- Don't attach unnecessary files
- Don't reply to spam

Sample formal email (exam-ready):

To: professor.sharma@muj.ac.in

Subject: Request for Feedback on Project Report — [Your Name], [Roll No]

Dear Professor Sharma,

I hope this email finds you well. I am writing to respectfully request your feedback on the project report I submitted on [date].

Your guidance will help me understand my strengths and areas of improvement. If convenient, I would appreciate a 10-minute meeting at your earliest availability.

Thank you for your time and support.

Regards,
[Your Full Name]
[Roll No] | [Branch] | [Contact]

✅ **Exam tip for email writing (Section C — 300–350 words):** Write the full email with ALL components visible (To, Subject, Salutation, Body paragraphs, Close, Signature). Word count the email itself. Use formal tone throughout. Don't be too brief — examiners expect 3 body paragraphs minimum.

LETTER WRITING

Why Letters Matter

- Official record — can be filed for future reference
- Communicate complex, confidential, or legally binding information
- Reach geographically distant clients/stakeholders
- Convey organisational professionalism

Standard Elements of a Business Letter

ELEMENT	DESCRIPTION	EXAMPLE
Letterhead / Date	Sender's organisation logo + current date	MUJ, 27 April 2026
Inside Address	Recipient's full name, title, and address	Dr. A Sharma, HOD, ...
Salutation	Formal greeting	Dear Dr. Sharma,
Subject Line	Brief topic of the letter	Re: Leave Application
Body	Introduction → Main Content → Conclusion/Request	3 clear paragraphs
Complimentary Close	Polite sign-off	Yours sincerely, / Regards,
Signature Block	Name, designation, contact	[Signed] Aryan Kumawat

Letter Layouts

FULL BLOCK

ALL elements aligned to the **left margin**. Most popular & modern format.

SEMI-BLOCK

Heading, close & signature are **right-aligned**; rest is left. Becoming outdated.

SIMPLIFIED

Omits salutation & complimentary close. Subject line in CAPS. Used in very formal/legal letters.

Elements of Style in Letter Writing

- **"You" approach** — focus on the reader's perspective, not yours
- **Be courteous and considerate** — never blame or accuse
- **Be simple and specific** — one paragraph, one idea
- **Avoid clichés** — e.g., "as per our discussion" is fine; "I am writing to inform you that..." is cliché
- **Use active voice** when possible — stronger and clearer
- **Distinguish "I" vs "We"** — "I" for personal views; "We" for organisational stance

Types of Letters (for awareness)

PROFESSIONAL LETTERS

- Acknowledgement letter
- Letter of recommendation
- Inquiry letter
- Complaint letter
- Credit and collection letter

PERSONAL/FORMAL LETTERS

- Leave application
- Letter of appreciation
- Goodwill letter
- Cover letter (with resume)
- Resignation letter

TECHNICAL WRITING VS. CREATIVE WRITING

ASPECT	TECHNICAL WRITING	CREATIVE WRITING
Purpose	Inform, instruct, document	Entertain, express, inspire
Audience	Specific, professional	General or literary audience
Style	Precise, objective, formal	Imaginative, subjective, flexible
Language	Jargon-specific, clear	Figurative, metaphorical
Examples	Reports, manuals, emails	Novels, poetry, short stories

PARAGRAPH WRITING

A paragraph is the basic unit of written communication. Every paragraph communicates **one central idea**.

Paragraph Structure:

1. **Topic Sentence** — states the main idea clearly
2. **Supporting Sentences** — provide evidence, examples, explanations (3–5 sentences)
3. **Concluding Sentence** — wraps up or transitions to the next paragraph

💡 **Types of paragraphs:** Narrative (tells a story), Descriptive (paints a picture), Expository (explains), Argumentative (persuades). For professional use, expository and argumentative are most common.

📋 PAST YEAR QUESTIONS — UNIT 3

ETE 2025 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Outline the structure of a professional email with an example.

Introduction: A professional email follows a standardised structure that ensures clarity, professionalism, and traceability.

Structure:

1. **Header:** To, CC/BCC fields; routes the email to the right recipients
2. **Subject Line:** Concise and informative — e.g., "Request for Project Feedback — Aryan Kumawat, 2024CSE001"
3. **Salutation:** "Dear Prof. Sharma," — formal and respectful
4. **Body:** (a) Opening — purpose of email; (b) Main content — details/request; (c) Closing — expected action/thanks
5. **Complimentary Close:** "Regards," or "Sincerely,"
6. **Signature:** Full name, roll number, branch, contact number

Example (abbreviated): *Subject: Attendance Query — 2024CSE001. Dear Prof. Sharma, I am writing to inquire about my attendance record for November 2025. Kindly advise on the process for regularisation. Regards, Aryan Kumawat.*

✅ **How to write:** Number the components, give a one-line example within the answer. Examiners need to see the structure AND an example — include both.

ETE 2025 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Mention two differences between technical writing and creative writing.

Difference 1 — Purpose and Audience: Technical writing aims to *inform or instruct* a specific professional audience (e.g., engineers, managers) using precise, objective language. Creative writing aims to *entertain or express* ideas to a general literary audience using imaginative, subjective language.

Difference 2 — Style and Language: Technical writing uses *jargon, structured formats* (reports, manuals, emails), and avoids ambiguity. Creative writing uses *figurative language, metaphor, and narrative* with freedom of expression — e.g., novels, poetry, short stories.

✅ **How to write:** The question says "two differences" — write exactly two, each as a bold-headed paragraph. Don't list more. Quality over quantity for 6 marks.

ETE 2025 10 Marks · Section C

Q. Write a short formal email to a professor requesting feedback on your project.

To: professor.gulab@muj.ac.in
CC: —
Subject: Request for Feedback on Communication Skills Project – Aryan Kumawat, 2024CSE089

Dear Professor Gulab Chand,

I hope this email finds you in good health. I am Aryan Kumawat, a student of B.Tech (CSE), Semester I, currently enrolled in your Communication Skills course (LLC1011).

I am writing to respectfully request your valuable feedback on the project report I submitted on 20th April 2026, titled "Effective Communication in Multicultural Teams." Your insights would greatly help me identify my strengths and areas requiring improvement before the end-term examination.

If it is convenient, I would appreciate a brief 10-minute discussion at your office, at a time of your choosing. Alternatively, feedback via email would be equally appreciated.

Thank you sincerely for your time and guidance. I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely,
Aryan Kumawat
Roll No: 2024CSE089 | B.Tech CSE, Semester I
Mobile: +91-XXXXXXXXXX | mujstella.in

✅ **How to write a 10-mark email:** This needs ~300 words. Write the FULL email — To, Subject, Salutation, 3 body paragraphs (intro → main request → closing), complimentary close, and full signature. Each paragraph serves a purpose. Formal language throughout — no contractions, no slang.

⚠ **Don't:** Write a 5-line email for a 10-mark question. Examiners expect full format + elaborated body. Expand each paragraph to 2-3 sentences minimum.

ETE 2025 10 Marks · Section C (Comprehension + Analysis)

Q. Read the Riya scenario. Identify the types of communication barriers and suggest ways to eliminate them.

Scenario Summary: Riya (project manager) leads a virtual meeting; she has a cold (physical barrier), team members have poor internet (technical/physical barrier), and a French recruit doesn't understand English (linguistic/cultural barrier).

Barriers Identified:

- **Physical Barrier:** Riya's cold makes her voice hoarse and unclear — the sender's physical condition distorts encoding. *Solution:* Use text-based backup (shared notes, real-time doc); reschedule if the sender is significantly impaired.

- **Technical/Channel Barrier:** Poor internet connectivity disrupts message transmission. *Solution:* Use a stable platform with auto-transcription (e.g., Google Meet + live captions); share recordings post-meeting.
- **Linguistic/Cultural Barrier:** The French recruit is not fluent in English — decoding fails. *Solution:* Provide meeting materials in advance, use simple language, avoid idioms; consider a multilingual liaison or translation support.

Overall Recommendations: Establish a pre-meeting checklist (connectivity test, shared agenda, language accessibility), use written meeting minutes to compensate for oral gaps, and implement a feedback round at the end of each meeting to confirm understanding.

> ✅ **How to write scenario-analysis answers:** (1) Briefly restate the scenario's key issues. (2) Name each barrier with its type in bold. (3) Pair each barrier with a specific, actionable solution. (4) End with 1–2 systemic recommendations. This structure guarantees marks even if your content is slightly different.

UNIT 4

Resume, Reading Skills, Precis & Soft Skills

> 💡 **What this unit is really about:** Applied written and reading competencies for professional and academic life. Resume questions are high-value (20 marks). Reading questions test whether you can apply skimming/scanning/comprehension strategies.

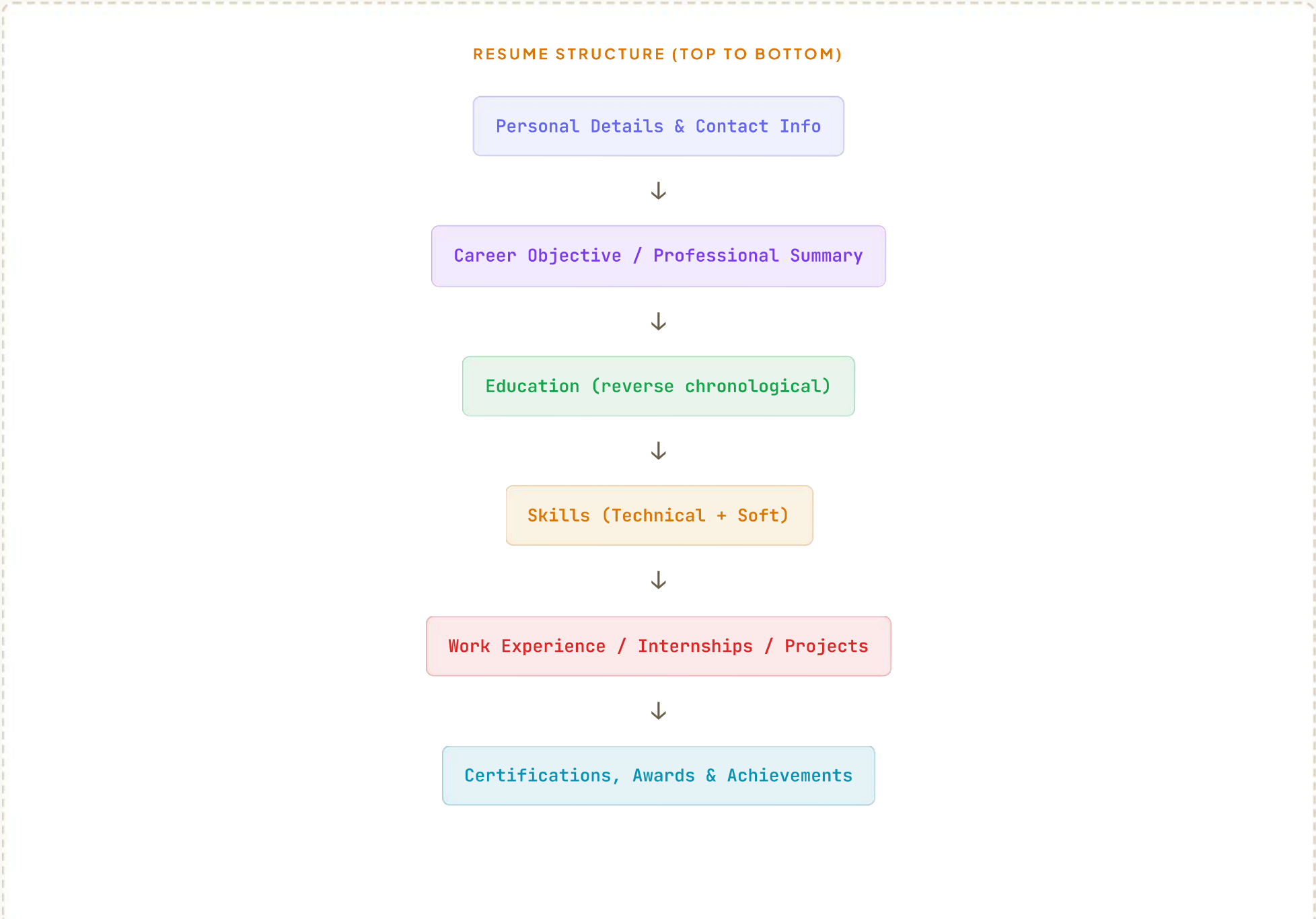
RESUME WRITING

A **resume** is a concise, tailored document that presents your education, skills, experience, and achievements to a potential employer. It is your *first impression* — a marketing document, not a biography.

Purpose of a Resume

- To secure an interview — not the job itself
- To demonstrate fit between your skills and the job requirements
- To communicate professionalism and attention to detail

Key Sections of a Resume



↓

`Hobbies & Extra-Curricular / References`

Resume Do's & Don'ts

✅ DO

- Keep it to **1 page** (freshers) or 2 pages max
- Use **action verbs**: Led, Developed, Achieved, Designed, Managed
- Tailor for each job — match keywords from job description
- Use consistent formatting — same font, spacing throughout
- Quantify achievements: "Increased efficiency by 30%"
- Include LinkedIn profile / GitHub / portfolio link
- Proofread meticulously — zero spelling errors
- Use a clean, professional font (Calibri, Arial, 10–12pt)

❌ DON'T

- Don't include a photo (unless region-specific norm)
- Don't list irrelevant experience or skills
- Don't use first-person pronouns ("I managed..." → "Managed...")
- Don't exaggerate or falsify information
- Don't use fancy colors, multiple fonts, or tables that won't parse in ATS
- Don't include marital status, religion, age (in most countries)
- Don't use a generic objective ("I want a challenging job...")
- Don't submit without tailoring to the role

🌟 **Strong Objective Example:**
"Results-driven B.Tech CSE student seeking a Software Development internship at [Company], where I can apply my Python and data structures expertise to build scalable solutions and contribute to the engineering team."

Weak (avoid): "To obtain a challenging position where I can use my skills."

Professional Social Media Profiling

Your **LinkedIn** profile is your digital resume. Key elements:

- **Professional headshot** — not a selfie or casual photo
- **Headline** — "B.Tech CSE Student | Python Developer | MUJ" (not just "Student")
- **About section** — 3–5 lines summarising your skills and goals
- **Featured projects** — link to GitHub, deployed apps, articles

- **Recommendations** — from professors, internship supervisors
- **Skills & Endorsements** — keep them relevant and updated

> ⚠️ **Digital footprint matters:** Recruiters search candidates online. Ensure your public social media profiles are professional. Privacy-lock personal accounts. Never post anything that could embarrass a future employer.

READING SKILLS

What is Reading?

Reading is a **psycholinguistic** (mind + language) process of extracting and constructing meaning from text. It requires knowledge of: writing system, language structure, interpretive ability, world knowledge, and a purpose.

Types / Techniques of Reading

TYPE	DEFINITION	WHEN USED	SPEED
Skimming	Reading quickly to get the *general idea / gist* of a text	Previewing an article, checking relevance of a book	Very fast
Scanning	Looking for *specific information* without reading everything	Finding a name in a directory, looking up a word in a dictionary	Very fast
Intensive Reading	Slow, careful reading of *shorter texts* for detailed comprehension	Research papers, contracts, exam questions	Slow
Extensive Reading	Reading *longer texts* rapidly for global understanding and pleasure	Novels, magazines for leisure	Moderate
Reading Aloud	Speaking the text — done when others need access to information	Reading news to someone without access	Slow

TYPE	DEFINITION	WHEN USED	SPEED
Silent Reading	Most efficient — full concentration on meaning without speaking	All private study; better comprehension than aloud	Moderate

Context Clues (for Vocabulary in Comprehension)

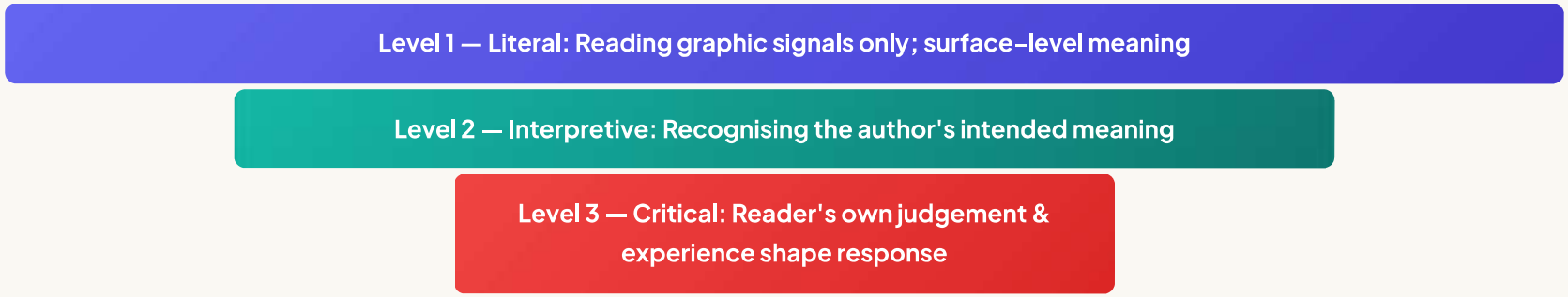
TYPE	SIGNAL WORDS	EXAMPLE
Synonyms / Restatement	or, that is, in other words	"The policy was *rescinded*, or cancelled, due to protests."
Antonyms / Contrast	but, however, on the other hand, in contrast	"He was active, not *stagnant*."
Cause / Effect	because, so, since, therefore, thus	"She studied hard; therefore she *excelled*."
Illustration / Example	for example, such as, like, including	"Modern devices, such as tablets and iPads, are portable."
Mood / Tone	emotional/descriptive language	"The *lugubrious* wails matched the dreary wind." (sad mood)

How to Approach Comprehension Passages (Exam Strategy)

1. **Skim first** — read the passage quickly for the main idea (30 sec)
2. **Read the questions first —** know what you're hunting for
3. **Scan for answers —** locate specific info using keywords from questions
4. **Re-read relevant sentences** carefully before answering
5. **Stay within the passage** — don't bring outside knowledge; stick to what's written
6. **Inference questions** — look for logical conclusions, not explicit statements

⚠️ **Assumption trap:** Comprehension questions penalise assumptions. If the passage doesn't say it directly or logically imply it, don't choose it. "The passage suggests" ≠ "The passage says."

Gray's Three Levels of Reading Comprehension



PRECIS / SUMMARY WRITING

A **précis** (pronounced "pray-see") is a condensed restatement of a text — typically **one-third** of the original word count — that retains all essential ideas without personal commentary.

Essentials of a Good Précis

QUALITY	MEANING
Completeness	Must contain all essential ideas — nothing important omitted
Compactness	Sense of unity — a comprehensive whole, not fragments
Conciseness	Economy of words — no repetitions, no ornamental phrases
Clarity	Clear expression — no circumlocution or ambiguity

Steps to Write a Précis

1. Read the original text carefully (2–3 times)
2. Identify the main idea and supporting points
3. Write in your own words — not the author's exact phrases
4. Use third-person, past tense, and indirect speech
5. Count words — aim for 1/3 of original length
6. Give a suitable title

📋 PAST YEAR QUESTIONS — UNIT 4

ETE 2025 2 Marks · Section A

Q. Name any two reading techniques.

Two important reading techniques are: (1) **Skimming** — reading rapidly to grasp the general idea or gist of a text without reading every word; and (2) **Scanning** — searching through a text quickly to locate a specific piece of information, such as a name, date, or fact.

> ✅ **How to write:** Name + one-line definition per technique. Never just list the names — add the definition for full marks even in a 2-mark question.

ETE 2025 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Examine the importance of professional social media profiling for career development.

Introduction: In the digital age, your online presence is an extension of your resume. Professional social media profiling — especially on LinkedIn — significantly influences hiring decisions.

1. Digital First Impression: Recruiters check LinkedIn before interviews. A complete, professional profile (headshot, headline, about section) signals seriousness and industry awareness.

2. Networking & Opportunities: Platforms connect students with alumni, mentors, and recruiters globally. A 2023 LinkedIn survey found 80% of jobs are filled through networking — often digital.

3. Personal Branding: Sharing articles, projects, and certifications positions you as a subject-matter contributor, not just a job seeker. This builds credibility over time.

4. Career Visibility: Recruiters use Boolean searches on platforms to find candidates. Keyword-optimised profiles (Python, Machine Learning, Communication Skills) surface in these searches.

Conclusion: Professional social media profiling transforms passive job-seeking into active career positioning. Students who invest early in their digital identity gain a competitive edge in placement seasons.

> ✅ **How to write:** 4 bold-headed points + intro + conclusion = clean 6-mark answer. Always include one statistic or real-world reference to elevate your answer.

ETE 2025 20 Marks · Section D (400–450 words)

Q. Examine the importance of a resume in the job application process. Highlight the do's and don'ts of resume writing and explain how to effectively tailor a resume to showcase skills, achievements, and experience.

Introduction: A resume is the cornerstone of the job application process — a strategically crafted document that compresses your professional identity into one concise page. It does not get you the job; it earns you the interview.

Importance of a Resume:

- **First Impression:** Before you walk into an interview, your resume speaks for you. It takes a recruiter 6–7 seconds to scan a resume — clarity and formatting are critical.
- **Demonstrates Fit:** A tailored resume mirrors the language and requirements of the job description, showing immediate alignment with the employer's needs.
- **Legal Record:** Employers verify resume claims. Accuracy is non-negotiable — falsification leads to immediate disqualification.
- **Personal Brand Document:** Your resume reflects not just what you've done, but how you communicate your value — a soft skill in itself.

Key Do's: Use action verbs (Led, Designed, Optimised); quantify achievements ("Reduced load time by 40%"); maintain consistent formatting; use a clean, ATS-friendly layout; tailor for each role; include LinkedIn profile; proofread ruthlessly.

Key Don'ts: Avoid first-person pronouns; don't include age, photo, religion (unless required); never exaggerate; don't use generic objectives; avoid irrelevant hobbies; don't exceed 2 pages for freshers.

Tailoring Your Resume:

1. **Analyse the Job Description:** Identify key required skills, technologies, and soft skills mentioned repeatedly.

2. **Mirror Keywords:** Incorporate the exact terms from the JD into your Skills and Experience sections — this bypasses ATS (Applicant Tracking Systems) filters.
3. **Prioritise Relevant Experience:** Lead with your most relevant project, internship, or certification for that role — don't bury it at the bottom.
4. **Customise the Objective:** Replace the generic objective with a role-specific, company-specific statement showing you understand their mission.
5. **Highlight Transferable Skills:** For freshers without direct experience, lead with academic projects, hackathons, competitions, or freelance work that demonstrates capability.

Conclusion: A resume is a living document — it must evolve with every new skill, project, and experience. The best resumes are not comprehensive lists; they are curated, strategic narratives that compel the reader to invite you for a conversation. Master the art of resume writing early, and it becomes your most powerful career tool.

✅ **20-mark answer strategy:** ~420 words. Use 4–5 labelled sections. Start with importance, then do's/don'ts in a sentence-format list (not just bullets), then the tailoring process as numbered steps. End with a strong conclusion. Examiners reward depth AND structure — this answer has both.

⚠ **Don't just list do's and don'ts in bullets** for a 20-mark question — that reads like a 6-mark answer. Add explanation, examples, and context around each point.

MAKEUP 2025-26 2 Marks · Section A

Q. In what way can poor paraphrasing distort information relay in customer-support teams?

When a customer-support agent paraphrases a client complaint inaccurately — e.g., "the app crashes occasionally" becomes "the app is broken" — the engineering team receives a distorted priority signal. This leads to wasted resources, incorrect fixes, and unresolved customer frustration, damaging brand trust.

✅ **How to write:** Concrete example + consequence. Show the distortion clearly with a before/after of the paraphrase, then name the downstream damage.

MAKEUP 2025-26 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Discuss the role of feedback in making communication effective.

Introduction: Feedback is the final, essential link in the communication chain — it transforms a one-way transmission into a true dialogue, confirming whether the message was received and understood as intended.

1. Confirms Understanding: Feedback signals whether the receiver decoded the message correctly. A nod, a reply email, or a question reveals comprehension level and prevents miscommunication.

2. Enables Error Correction: When feedback reveals a misunderstanding, the sender can immediately clarify, re-encode, or choose a different channel — correcting the communication loop in real time.

3. Motivates the Sender: Positive feedback (verbal praise, acknowledgement) encourages continued communication. Constructive feedback helps the sender improve their encoding and delivery.

4. Makes Communication Dynamic: Feedback shifts communication from static (monologue) to dynamic (dialogue). It is the mechanism that keeps conversations productive and relationships healthy.

Conclusion: Without feedback, communication is assumption. With feedback, it becomes connection. Effective organisations build cultures where feedback is welcomed, frequent, and specific.

✅ **How to write:** 4 bold-headed points + intro + conclusion. Each point = 2 sentences max. The conclusion should be a quotable one-liner — examiners remember them.

MAKEUP 2025-26 10 Marks · Section C

Q. Explain how groupthink and status barriers interacted to destroy problem-solving efficiency in a meeting scenario. Propose communication-based corrective strategies.

Scenario: In a product review meeting at a tech company, junior developers notice critical security flaws in the software. However, the senior VP (high-status figure) has already endorsed the product launch. Due to *groupthink* — the desire for harmony — and *status barriers* — fear of contradicting authority — no one raises concerns. The product launches, and the flaws are exploited within weeks.

How Groupthink Operated: Members suppressed individual doubts, self-censored, and created a false illusion of consensus. Dissenting voices were socially penalised (eye-rolls, dismissal), reinforcing silence.

How Status Barriers Amplified It: The VP's authority created a psychological "speaking-up tax" — the perceived cost of disagreeing with power exceeded the perceived benefit of raising a concern. Junior members with valid insights stayed silent.

Corrective Communication Strategies:

- **Anonymous Feedback Channels:** Use pre-meeting surveys or anonymous digital polls (Mentimeter, Slido) to surface dissenting views before the meeting — removes the social cost of speaking up.
- **Devil's Advocate Role:** Formally assign someone to argue against the dominant position in every major meeting — makes criticism institutionally safe.
- **Psychological Safety Culture:** Leaders should explicitly invite disagreement: "I want to hear what's not working." This signals that challenge is welcome, not threatening.
- **Structured Decision Protocols:** Use a checklist (e.g., pre-mortem analysis: "Assume this fails — why?") before finalising any decision to force critical thinking.

Conclusion: Groupthink and status barriers are silent killers of organisational intelligence. The antidote is a culture where communication norms actively encourage — not just tolerate — honest dissent.

> ✅ **How to write:** Open with a vivid concrete scenario. Then separately analyse each barrier (groupthink + status). Then 4 bulleted corrective strategies, each with a name and brief explanation. Close with a sharp conclusion. This answers both "explain" and "propose" parts — always answer all parts of a multi-part question.

✨ QUICK REFERENCE: ANSWER LENGTH GUIDE

SECTION	WORD COUNT	MARKS	STRATEGY
Section A	20–30 words	2 each	Name + 1 line definition / example. Be precise. No padding.
Section B	150–200 words	6 each	Intro + 3–4 bold-headed points + conclusion. Use real examples.
Section C	300–350 words	10	Full format (for emails/letters) or scenario analysis with solutions. 5+ paragraphs.
Section D	400–500 words	20	6–7 labelled sections. Include model/framework/list. Conclude strongly.

🌟 **Final Exam Tips:**

1. **Read the question twice —** note every verb (define, analyse, examine, compare) and answer accordingly.
2. **Structure first, write second —** 30 seconds planning saves 5 minutes of rambling.
3. **Bold your key terms** — makes answers scannable and shows confidence.
4. **One strong example beats three vague ones** — concrete > abstract.
5. **Always conclude** — even a one-liner conclusion signals a complete, disciplined answer.

EXTRAS

Supplementary Topics & Missing PYQ Answers

⚠️ **These topics appear in the lecture notes and PYQs but don't fit neatly into one unit.** Cover these for full syllabus safety — especially Blog Writing, Telephonic Skills, and the Technology-in-Communication 10-mark PYQ.

EFFECTIVE INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION — TIPS

Interpersonal communication is the sharing of information between two or more people — face-to-face or mediated. It is the most common form of communication in professional life.

💡 **Key insight:** Interpersonal communication includes BOTH verbal and non-verbal components, and feedback is an integral part. It can be formal (office meeting) or informal (lunch chat).

TIP	WHY IT MATTERS
Always keep the receiver in mind	Adapt your vocabulary, tone, and medium to the listener's background and needs
Create an open communication environment	Psychological safety encourages honest, two-way dialogue
Don't communicate when emotionally disturbed	Emotions hijack encoding — wait until calm to send important messages
Be aware of cultural/language diversity	What's polite in one culture may be rude in another (e.g., eye contact norms)
Understand & use appropriate non-verbal cues	55% of meaning is conveyed through body language — align it with your words
Select the most suitable medium	Sensitive topics: face-to-face. Quick updates: messaging. Formal records: email.
Analyse the feedback	Feedback reveals whether your message was decoded correctly — act on it

TELEPHONIC SKILLS

Telephonic communication is a **paralingual** channel — the receiver cannot see you, so *voice, tone, pace, and clarity* carry the entire message. Professional telephone etiquette is critical in business and customer-facing roles.

✅ TELEPHONIC BEST PRACTICES

- **Identify yourself immediately** — "Good morning, this is Aryan from MUJ, CSE department."
- **Or identify via designation** — callers may not know you by name; your role clarifies context
- **Maintain courtesy at all times** — even with unknown callers; tone sets the entire interaction
- **Avoid putting callers on hold** — if unavoidable, offer to call back and keep that promise
- **Don't promise a callback unless you can fulfil it** — if not, ask them to call again at a specific time
- **End the call pleasantly** — "Thank you for calling. Have a great day!" leaves a positive impression

❌ TELEPHONIC DON'TS

- Don't eat, drink, or multitask while on a professional call
- Don't use speakerphone in public/noisy areas
- Don't answer a call with just "Hello?" — always identify
- Don't let the phone ring more than 3 times before answering
- Don't use slang or casual language in formal calls
- Don't cut the call abruptly — always close formally

- **Speak clearly and at moderate pace** — no filler words (um, uh), no interrupting

🌟 **Why this matters in exams:** Telephonic skills can appear as a comparison question ("Compare email communication with telephonic communication") or as a direct 6-mark B-section. The key contrast: telephone = immediate but no record; email = asynchronous but documented.

BLOG WRITING

A **blog** (shortened from "weblog") is an online discussion or information site — essentially a *digital personal diary or knowledge-sharing platform* where posts are typically displayed in reverse chronological order.

ELEMENT	DETAILS
Definition	A blog is an online platform for sharing ideas, information, experiences, or opinions with a wider audience. It is a type of website where content (posts) is updated regularly.
Structure	Header (navigation bar) → Main content area (highlighted/latest posts) → Sidebar (social profiles, call-to-action) → Footer (privacy policy, contact links)
Purpose	For business, projects, earning money, personal expression, connecting with a relevant audience
Types	Personal, Collaborative/Group, Micro-blogging (Twitter/X), Corporate/Organizational, Aggregated
Examples	Food blogs, Tech blogs, Travel blogs, Personal development blogs, Entrepreneur blogs
Benefits	Promotes self-expression, sharpens creative thinking, improves writing & communication skills, builds personal brand, shares knowledge

✍️ **Exam tip:** Blog writing can appear as "Define blog and explain its types and benefits" (6 marks). Structure: Definition (2 lines) + Types with brief descriptions + Benefits as bullets. Don't confuse blog with social media posts — a blog is long-form, structured content.

📋 MISSING PYQ ANSWERS — MAKEUP 2025-26

MAKEUP 2025-26 2 Marks · Section A

Q. Why can eye contact norms in global teams lead to misjudgment of confidence levels? Give one instance.

Eye contact norms vary significantly across cultures: Western cultures equate **sustained eye contact with confidence and honesty**, while East Asian and South Asian cultures may view it as **disrespectful or challenging authority**. In a global team, an Indian engineer who avoids eye contact with a senior (a cultural sign of respect) may be misread by an American manager as *lacking confidence or being evasive*, resulting in unfair performance assessments.

> ✅ **How to write:** Name the two contrasting cultural norms → give the exact instance → name the misjudgement. All in 25–30 words. This tests knowledge of **Oculesics** (the study of eye contact in communication) — use that term if possible.

MAKEUP 2025-26 2 Marks · Section A

Q. Identify one barrier that occurs when employees rely on "hearing" instead of "listening" during safety briefings.

When employees merely **hear** a safety briefing — perceiving sounds without active cognitive engagement — they fail to retain critical procedural details (e.g., emergency exit locations). This creates a **psychological/semantic barrier**: the message was transmitted but never processed, resulting in unsafe behaviour and potential accidents.

> ✅ **How to write:** Name the barrier type (psychological — lack of attention), explain why hearing ≠ listening, and give the real-world consequence. Safety context makes the stakes concrete.

MAKEUP 2025-26 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Evaluate a case where an employee's public-speaking style unintentionally threatened hierarchy or power dynamics in a meeting.

Introduction: Public speaking style — including assertiveness, vocabulary, and command — carries implicit signals about authority. When a subordinate's style inadvertently challenges power dynamics, it creates organisational friction.

Case: Priya, a junior analyst at a consulting firm, presents quarterly findings to senior partners. She speaks with TED-talk-like authority — confident posture, direct assertions, zero hedging language ("The data clearly shows..." rather than "I think perhaps..."). While her content is accurate, senior partners feel their expertise is being sidelined. The VP interrupts her mid-slide, re-frames her conclusions, and subtly undermines her in Q&A.

Analysis: Priya's style was mistaken for *overreach* — she communicated as a peer in a hierarchical context. The threat was unintentional but real: her vocal confidence and lack of deference language ("In my humble view...") activated the VP's status-protection instinct.

Lesson: Effective professional communication requires **contextual style-switching** — the same content delivered with appropriate hedging, acknowledgement of senior input, and incremental assertion is better received without sacrificing substance.

> ✅ **How to write:** Real/realistic case + analysis of what went wrong + a clear lesson or correction. Always name the communication concept at play (status barriers, style-switching, hedging language).

MAKEUP 2025-26 10 Marks · Section C

Q. "Technology improves communication speed but damages nuance." Using five high-stakes situations (telemedicine, legal consultation, sales negotiation, HR conflict resolution, academic supervision), evaluate this claim.

Introduction: Technology has collapsed geographical barriers and accelerated information exchange exponentially. Yet speed comes with a cost — the subtle, context-rich layers of human communication are often lost in digital transmission. Evaluating five high-stakes domains reveals this paradox sharply.

1. Telemedicine: A doctor can now consult patients across continents via video call — speed is revolutionary. However, digital channels strip away crucial *haptic cues* (skin pallor, temperature, physical examination) and reduce the patient's ability to convey nuanced symptoms. A patient's hesitant body language signalling hidden depression may be missed entirely on a pixelated screen. *Speed ✓ | Nuance ✗*

2. Legal Consultation: Lawyers use email and document-sharing platforms for efficiency. But the law is built on precise nuance — a client's emotional state, unspoken fears, or contradictory micro-expressions during consultation often reveal information crucial to case strategy. These disappear in text-based communication. *Speed ✓ | Nuance ✗*

3. Sales Negotiation: Real-time messaging and CRM tools accelerate deal cycles. However, negotiation is fundamentally a reading of *proxemics, tone, and hesitation*. A buyer's pause before answering signals consideration; in chat, that pause is invisible — leading to premature concessions or missed closing opportunities. *Speed ✓ | Nuance ✗*

4. HR Conflict Resolution: HR can rapidly document grievances and loop in management via email chains. But conflict resolution requires empathy, active listening, and safe dialogue — qualities deeply diminished when reduced to asynchronous text messages. A comma in an HR email can trigger entirely different interpretations. *Speed ✓ | Nuance ✗*

5. Academic Supervision: Learning Management Systems (LMS) allow instant feedback on submissions. Yet the mentor-mentee relationship is built on trust, encouragement, and adaptive guidance — elements requiring in-person rapport. A student's existential anxiety about their research cannot be resolved by a Turnitin report. *Speed ✓ | Nuance ✗*

Conclusion: The claim is well-supported: technology is a speed amplifier but a nuance compressor. The solution is not to abandon technology but to use it strategically — reserving high-bandwidth, face-to-face channels for nuance-critical conversations, and using digital tools for efficiency where stakes are lower. *Technology should be a communication aid, not a communication replacement.*

✅ **How to write this:** The question gives you the 5 situations — use them as 5 mini-paragraphs. Each = one situation + speed advantage + nuance loss + a concrete example. The pattern "Speed ✓ | Nuance ✗" after each is a great structural signal. Intro + 5 cases + conclusion = ~330 words = 10 marks. Never skip any of the named situations — the examiner checks all 5.

⚠ **Common mistake:** Writing only about technology in general without using all 5 specific contexts. The question is testing whether you can *apply* the concept, not just state it.

MAKEUP 2025-26 6 Marks · Section B

Q. Investigate how reading-comprehension failures contributed to a real incident of financial, legal, or operational error.

Introduction: Reading comprehension is not merely an academic skill — in professional contexts, a failure to read accurately can cascade into financial, legal, or operational catastrophe.

Case — The Typo That Cost $440 Million: In 2012, Knight Capital Group, a US trading firm, suffered a catastrophic trading loss of $440 million in 45 minutes. A trader failed to read and fully comprehend the deployment documentation for new trading software, resulting in the accidental activation of an obsolete algorithm. The operational manual was misread — key lines about disabling legacy code were either skimmed or misunderstood.

Reading Failure Analysis: The team employed *skimming* where *intensive reading* was required. Critical conditional clauses in the technical document (specifying when to disable the old system) were overlooked. This is a semantic comprehension failure — understanding individual words but missing the interdependency of clauses.

Lesson: High-stakes documents demand *intensive, critical reading* — not scanning. Organisations should implement mandatory comprehension checklists for critical operational changes, and build a culture where "I need to re-read this" is encouraged, not stigmatised.

> ✅ **How to write:** Use a real or realistic case (Knight Capital is a real, well-documented example). Name the reading failure type explicitly (skimming vs. intensive reading). Connect it back to the comprehension concept from the syllabus. Conclude with a corrective practice.

MAKEUP 2025-26 6 Marks · Section B

Q. A project collapses because a team misread non-verbal cues during negotiation. Break down the cues and their interpretation errors.

Introduction: Non-verbal communication accounts for 55% of interpersonal meaning. Misreading these cues during high-stakes negotiations can lead to catastrophic misjudgements.

Scenario: A startup team negotiates a licensing deal with a corporate client. The client's representative nods occasionally, maintains brief eye contact, and says little. The startup team interprets this as agreement and enthusiasm — they reduce their price, assuming goodwill. The deal collapses when the client declines.

Cue Breakdown & Interpretation Errors:

- **Nodding (Kinesics):** Startup interpreted as "yes/agreement." In East Asian corporate culture, it signals *"I am listening"* — not approval. *Error: Cultural kinesic misreading.*
- **Minimal Eye Contact (Oculesics):** Read as "focused attention." Was actually a sign of *discomfort and disengagement. Error: Positive attribution to a negative cue.*
- **Silence (Chronemics/Paralingual):** Interpreted as *contemplation and interest.* Actually signalled *dissatisfaction and unwillingness to commit. Error: Silence ≠ consent.*

Lesson: Negotiators must develop *cultural non-verbal literacy* and use verbal confirmation alongside cue-reading: "I want to confirm — does nodding here indicate agreement?" Explicitly verbalising interpretations prevents costly misreads.

✅ **How to write:** Name each non-verbal cue with its technical term (kinesics, oculesics, chronemics). State what it was interpreted as vs. what it actually meant. The mismatch IS the answer. Always use the syllabus vocabulary — it signals to examiners you studied the course, not just common sense.